

Interconnection of Large Loads to the)
Interstate Transmission System) **Docket No. RM26-4-000**

² *Ensuring the timely and Orderly Interconnection of Large Loads*, Docket No. RM26-4-000 (October 23, 2025).

Thomas Lemon Senior Counsel Eversource Energy Service Company 247 Station Drive SE100 Westwood, MA 02090 thomas.lemon@eversource.com	David J. Burnham Director, Transmission Policy Eversource Energy Service Company 56 Prospect Street Hartford, CT 06103 david.burnham@eversource.com
---	--

II. DESCRIPTION OF EVERSOURCE

Eversource Energy is a Fortune 500 energy company that operates New England’s largest energy delivery system, with an extensive network of over 61,000 circuit miles of electric transmission and distribution lines. Eversource Energy’s utility subsidiaries transmit and deliver retail electricity, natural gas, and water to approximately 4.4 million customers in Connecticut, Massachusetts, and New Hampshire.

The Eversource public utilities own and operate transmission facilities primarily in the states of Connecticut, Massachusetts, and New Hampshire. The Eversource public utilities’ transmission facilities are used to provide transmission service under the ISO New England Inc. (“ISO-NE”) Open Access Transmission Tariff. Eversource currently has approximately 225 MW of transmission-interconnected load across its service territory and approximately 800 MW of load under study for future transmission load interconnections.

III. COMMENTS

Similar to the circumstances that prompted Order Nos. 1920³ and 2023,⁴ the Commission is again faced with an unprecedented sea change in the industry: in this case the rapid onset of the interconnection of large loads, especially data center and electrification projects. Eversource supports the need for clarity and additional certainty in the complex and unsettled regulatory

³ *Building for the Future Through Electric Regional Transmission Planning and Cost Allocation*, Order No. 1920, 187 FERC ¶ 61,068 (2024), *order on reh’g*, Order No. 1920-A, 189 FERC ¶ 61,126 (2024).

⁴ *Improvements to Generator Interconnection Procs. & Agreements*, Order No. 2023, 184 FERC ¶ 61,054 (2023), *order on reh’g*, Order No. 2023-A, 186 FERC ¶ 61,199 (2024).

space of the interconnection of large loads to Commission-jurisdictional transmission systems, but an overly prescriptive and restrictive final rule arising out of this proceeding could result in more harm than the status quo to prospective large load customers, interconnecting transmission owners, and the public generally. Accordingly, Eversource recommends that the focus of any final rule arising out of this proceeding focus on improving the efficiency of the large-load interconnection process without being overly prescriptive. As further explained below, implementing a strict, one-size-fits-all interconnection process will impede rather than facilitate the interconnection of these large loads. Given the extreme complexities and variability of the types of loads and their desired service arrangements, the Commission should also ensure that any final rule provides sufficient flexibility to address the different needs of large-load customers. Also as further discussed below, Eversource appreciates that the ANOPR appears not to disturb, and should not disturb, certain existing beneficial transmission arrangements between utilities and their retail customers. These arrangements should also remain available to prospective large-load customers as they are often faster and more flexible than traditional federal interconnection processes. Finally, to the extent the Commission wishes to consider folding large loads into the Order No. 2023 cluster study process, it should not make participation in that process mandatory for large loads and allow these loads to either 1) receive electric service via retail arrangements or 2) utilize an alternative serial study process.

A. The Commission should allow for sufficient flexibility to improve the efficiency and effectiveness of the large-load interconnection process without being overly prescriptive

The ANOPR is grounded in not only making the interconnection process for large loads efficient, but also making it *timely*.⁵ Accordingly, the Commission should not sacrifice

⁵ ANOPR at P 1.

timeliness and efficiency on the altar of prescriptive uniformity. While almost all generators are fundamentally similar (in that their sole purpose is to generate electricity for consumption), the same cannot be said for loads, whose characteristics can vary wildly depending on their purpose, use, location, and history. As the Commission recognizes,⁶ large loads are not just data centers, although data centers represent a significant and important form of prospective large load. Large loads also include electrode boilers and chillers for large-scale steam and HVAC service, utility-scale vehicle fleet charging, and numerous other projects essential to the development of modern infrastructure. Any final rule arising out of this proceeding must be flexible enough to accommodate different load types and their needs. This flexibility can manifest both in customer choice between a wholesale and retail process discussed below (essential in assuring that necessary large loads, including datacenters, are built in a timely and efficient manner) and in regional flexibility (as the physical and electrical topography of systems vary among regions).

Similarly, the final rule should also be flexible enough to encompass different “hybrid” load arrangements, including those co-located with generation seeking standby service, behind-the-meter generation with voluntary curtailment/isolation, and other arrangements that may be sought by customers. If a full notice of proposed rulemaking issues in this proceeding, the Commission should provide and specifically seek comment on an exhaustive list of all different load interconnection arrangements that would need to be addressed and then ensure that any final rule provide the flexibility to address each form of load interconnection arrangement.. The final rule should also be flexible enough to allow transmission providers to develop and address region-specific rules and concerns (such as termination of co-located generator interconnection rights). As the Commission notes, the reliability impacts of all permissible configurations of

⁶ ANOPR at p. 2.

hybrid loads must be addressed through reliability, study, and operational requirements pursuant to any final interconnection process developed in this proceeding.

Finally, any major change in regulation or processes in interconnection can have unintended consequences, and the more prescriptive such a process is the more likely that entities (including customers, transmission owners, and RTO/ISOs) will lack the flexibility to address these consequences without hindering the interconnection process. Such flexibility could either be included in the process described in the final rule or through the accommodation of regional variations as part of the compliance process.

B. The Commission should preserve existing retail transmission arrangements and allow future large-load interconnections to avail themselves of the retail process

Eversource currently serves several retail customers at transmission voltages, primarily at 115 kilovolts. In the ISO-NE region, load seeking to interconnect to the transmission system may either apply directly to ISO-NE and the applicable local transmission owner for service or have their utility procure transmission service on their behalf and receive electric service through a state-jurisdictional retail arrangement. Currently, if a prospective transmission-interconnected load applies for service through ISO-NE, such a load participates in the ISO-NE cluster study process as described by the interconnection procedures contained in the ISO-NE Tariff and will be responsible for its portion of the network upgrades identified by the cluster study. If a customer instead chooses retail service, their system impact and network upgrade responsibilities are determined by an individual impact study performed by the Transmission Owner.

In Eversource's experience, prospective large loads overwhelmingly prefer the retail construct. The retail arrangement for transmission-interconnected electric service provides significant advantages to the customer as it allows the customer to function as an end-use, state-jurisdictional customer for the sale of electricity while simultaneously allowing the transmission

provider to deploy its own expertise in the complex federal interconnection space. Unlike large, transmission-interconnected generators whose primary purpose and activity will be in Commission-jurisdictional markets following their interconnection and being placed in-service, end-use retail (rather than wholesale) purchasers of electricity such as large loads do not engage in the purchase or sale of electricity as their primary business model. Accordingly, the more turnkey solutions available under the umbrella of retail electric service are often preferable.

Furthermore, state processes must necessarily account for regional differences and be more responsive to local needs, including potentially the flexibility required by large loads. Retail processes can in some cases also result in the timelier interconnection of loads relative to federal-jurisdictional process, primarily due to the fixed nature of cluster study processes required by Order No. 2023. However, there are also advantages to directly applying for transmission and interconnection service via a FERC-jurisdictional process, including greater certainty, potentially reduced costs, and the reduction in network upgrade costs due to the efficiencies inherent in the shared cluster network upgrade construct. Accordingly, the Commission should preserve both existing and prospective retail interconnections at transmission voltages in order to efficiently interconnect large loads to the system. Given the nature of the system impacts of exceptionally large loads, the Commission could consider a voltage or MW threshold (likely much greater than 20 MW) such that transmission providers could still require the largest loads to participate in a federal interconnection process. However, any specific threshold may result in loads artificially reducing their capacity to just below that threshold to avoid such requirements, which could result in greater inefficiencies overall.

C. The Commission Should Not Require Load to Participate in Generator Cluster Study Processes

The ANOPR states that load and hybrid facilities should be studied together with generating facilities “to the extent practicable.”⁷ While combined studies could result in enhanced efficiencies, the strict and often lengthy study timelines for generator interconnection may not be practically feasible with the tight timelines for the interconnection of large loads, which can either be subject to state-mandated service dates (such as through electrification) or whose viability is based on rapid development and construction (such as data centers). Accordingly, to the extent any final rule arising out of this proceeding contemplates including qualifying loads in the Order No. 2023-mandated cluster study process, such inclusion should be optional. This will allow loads without major time pressures to reap the benefits and efficiencies of the cluster study process (such as reduced network upgrade costs) while not threatening the viability of other load projects for whom the cluster study process and timeline present insurmountable barriers to entry. Furthermore, given the lengthy timelines for Order No. 2023 cluster studies, the Commission should consider not including loads in that process at all due to the time pressures described above.

The Commission also contemplates an expedited study process for curtailable or dispatchable loads and hybrid facilities.⁸ The Commission could also create an expedited study process for all large loads under significant time pressure, or allow those loads to avail themselves of state retail processes. In Eversource’s experience, none of its current or prospective large load customers have expressed any interest in mandatory/dispatchable curtailment. To the extent the Commission wishes to establish such an alternative process for

⁷ ANOPR at P 20.

⁸ See ANOPR at P 24.

dispatchable facilities, it should ensure that its eligibility requirements dovetail with what prospective customers are seeking. Such eligibility requirements could include non-dispatchable but voluntarily curtailment (or perhaps a penalty rate structure for failure to follow requested curtailments).

IV. CONCLUSION

Eversource appreciates the opportunity to submit comments on this important matter and respectfully requests that the Commission consider these comments.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Vandan Divatia

Vandan Divatia
Vice President, Transmission Policy &
Compliance
Eversource Energy Service Company

Dated: November 21, 2025